AI IN GOVERNMENT AND PUBLIC SERVICES - VOLUME 4

The Permitting, Planning and Land Use Playbook

Permission to build, decided in the open: applications checked once, codes tested transparently, places understood whole - with AI that checks, maps and drafts, and planners who decide.



Gates P0-P5 | 8 Templates | 20 Golden Rules

The worked example continues: **Northbridge City and County**, a fictional composite government of 480,000 residents receiving 31,000 permit and planning applications a year - from porch extensions to a 2,400-home new quarter - across a register of 196,000 parcels. Every figure attached to Northbridge is illustrative. Adapt thresholds to your own code, plan and risk appetite.

Executive / Service / Accountability lenses on every major section, so an elected member, an applicant and an auditor can read the same page and each find their decision.

START HERE

Planning is where a city argues with itself - lawfully

Volume 2 built the front door and Volume 3 the casework behind it. This volume owns the decisions that shape the physical place: what may be built, where, to what standard, and on what conditions - and the plan that makes those decisions coherent over twenty years, not twenty applications.

How to use this playbook

- **Planning and permitting leads** read pages 4-18 and run every use case against the gates on page 29.
- **Executives and elected members** read pages 6, 24-26 and 29, and hold the stop list on page 7 personally.
- **Planners, inspectors and plan-makers** read pages 9-23 first; their desk is designed there, not in the vendor demo.
- **Auditors and oversight** start at pages 23, 27 and 29-32: the register, failure drills, gates, templates and rules.

The one test that matters

Every design choice answers one question: **does this help a qualified planner make a lawful, explainable decision about a real place, faster - without hiding the judgement inside the tool?** Speed bought by skipping consultation, softening a code check or burying a reason is not speed; it is an appeal, an inquiry or a judicial review waiting for a date.

AI checks. Planners decide. **The permission, the refusal and the reason are always human-owned and publicly recorded.**

EXECUTIVE LENS

Own the appeal-upheld rate and the build quality rate; they matter more than the decision time.

SERVICE LENS

A case is progressed when the applicant and the neighbours know what was decided, why, and what happens next.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every automated check leaves a trace an auditor - and an appellant - can follow to the code, the drawing and the data.

THE SERIES

Where this volume sits

Vol	Title	Owns
1	Strategy	Mandate, portfolio, risk tiers, gates S0-S5
2	Citizen Services and Digital Front Doors	Find, understand, apply, track, contact
3	Benefits, Licensing and Casework	Eligibility support, evidence, caseworker tools
4	Permitting, Planning and Land Use	Applications, code checks, consultation, inspections, plan-making (this volume)
5	Tax, Revenue and Compliance	Filing support, queries, payment, debt
6	Procurement and Supplier AI	Buying, contracts, model and supplier governance
7	Emergency Services and Public Safety	Dispatch support, triage, public alerts
8	Data, Records and Interoperability	Registers, records, sharing, retention
9	Workforce, Ethics and Public Trust	Roles, skills, ethics review, public reporting
10	Government Capstone and Assurance	Whole-portfolio assurance and the licence to scale

Contents of this volume

Permitting today: delay is usually design	4
The application lifecycle, end to end	5
Where AI pays in permitting and planning	6
The stop list: judgements AI never makes	7
Ten design principles	8
Pre-application: the right route, first time	9
The code, as code: zoning and standards	10
Completeness: checked once, kindly	11
Drawings, plans and document intelligence	12
Site, constraints and the parcel record	13
Consultation that people can actually join	14
Environment, heritage and design: support, not verdicts	15
Assessment: the officer report, drafted not decided	16
Conditions, obligations and legal agreements	17
Decisions, reasons and the notice	18
Inspections and enforcement: risk-based, human-led	19
Appeals, challenges and learning loops	20
Plan-making: evidence, scenarios and the local plan	21
The planner desk and the working day	22
Trust, records and the public planning register	23
Measurement: fast, fair, built right	24
Economics of permitting and planning	25
Workforce: judgement about place is the job	26
When permitting AI fails	27
Build, buy and supplier discipline	28
Gates P0-P5 and the 24-month roadmap	29
Templates 1-4	30
Templates 5-8 and the assurance checklist	31
20 Golden Rules	32

DIAGNOSIS

Delay is usually design, not applicants

Northbridge audited 1,500 decided applications before automating anything. Most elapsed time was queue, not assessment: files waiting for a completeness check, a consultee reply, a site visit slot, a signature. A quarter of applications were invalid on arrival - wrong form, missing drawing scale, a fee short by a small amount - and each invalid return restarted a clock the applicant thought was running.

What the audit counts

- **Invalid rate and its causes:** every return names the missing item in plain language - patterns, not anecdotes, drive the fix.
- **Waits by owner:** applicant, consultee, internal queue, committee cycle. A wait with no owner and no chasing rule is a decision to delay.
- **Re-consultation:** schemes sent back to consultees because the first pack was incomplete or amended drawings were never version-checked.
- **Post-decision failure:** conditions never discharged, inspections missed, permissions built differently from the drawings - speed at decision, cost at completion.

> **Northbridge baseline (illustrative):** median householder decision 11 weeks against an 8-week standard; 26 percent invalid on arrival; 19 percent of major applications re-consulted at least once; one in six discharged conditions later found not to match what was built.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund the audit before the model. Automating this workflow would refuse valid schemes faster and miss unbuilt conditions sooner.

SERVICE LENS

Attack invalid returns and ownerless waits first; they are larger than any model's time saving.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish the baseline - decision times, invalid rates, appeal outcomes - before claiming any improvement.

THE WORK

One application, one lifecycle, no black holes

A porch, a shopfront and a new quarter differ in scale but share a skeleton. Name the stages, give each an owner and a clock, and let applicants and neighbours see the same map the planner sees.

Stage	What happens	AI may	Planner owns
Pre-application	Route, constraints and advice before money is spent	Assemble the parcel record and likely issues	The advice given and its limits
Submission	Application, drawings and fee received	Extract data, validate files, acknowledge instantly	Confirming validity and starting the clock
Completeness	Checked against the published list	Test each item, flag gaps once, in plain language	Deciding validity and any waiver
Consultation	Neighbours and consultees respond	Summarise and cluster responses, cited	Weighing representations in the balance
Assessment	Proposal tested against plan and code	Assemble code trace, constraints and draft report	The planning judgement and recommendation
Decision	Granted, granted with conditions, or refused	Draft the notice from the signed report	Signing, issuing and standing behind it
Build and inspect	Work proceeds, conditions discharged	Schedule risk-based visits, compare as-built evidence	Certifying compliance and acting on breach
Appeal / review	Decision challenged and re-examined	Summarise grounds, route to a fresh reviewer	The response and the learning it triggers

The lifecycle rule: an application is never in a state with no owner, no next action and no date. A register that counts files but cannot say who is waiting for what is decoration.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Manage the lifecycle, not the inbox. Queues hide; stages with clocks do not.

SERVICE LENS

Show applicants and neighbours the stage map. Most anger is not the wait, it is not knowing.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every stage transition is recorded: who, when, on what evidence. That record is the appeal file.

THE OPPORTUNITY

AI pays in checking, mapping and summarising

Planner time splits into validating, measuring, mapping, chasing, summarising and judging. The first five are volume work where AI earns its keep. Judging - the balance of plan, place and impact - is the planner's statutory act (page 7).

Use	What it does	Pay-off
Completeness check	Tests a submission against the published validation list	Applicants fix gaps once, early, in plain language
Drawing extraction	Reads scales, dimensions and labels from plans into structured data	No re-measuring; code checks run on real numbers
Code pre-check	Tests measurable standards - height, setback, parking, daylight angles	Clear passes cleared fast; borderline cases reach a planner sooner
Parcel and constraints pack	Builds the site record: designations, history, flood, heritage, trees	One trusted starting point for applicant, planner and consultee
Consultation summary	Clusters representations by issue, cited to source, duplicates counted honestly	Planners read the argument, not 400 near-identical letters one by one
Officer report draft	Drafts the report structure from the signed evidence and code trace	Planner time moves to judgement, site and negotiation
Inspection scheduling	Ranks visit need by risk and condition deadlines, for human approval	Inspectors go where breach would hurt most
Plan evidence scans	Summarises consultation and data for plan-making, with sources	Evidence bases assembled in weeks, kept current

Start where planners **drown in paper and measurement**, not where they weigh competing goods. The savings are real and the risk is containable.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sequence by planner pain and challenge cost: completeness, extraction and parcel packs before anything clever.

SERVICE LENS

Every use above checks, maps or drafts; a person or a deterministic rule still commits the outcome.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If a summary cannot cite its sources in the file, it does not go on the file.

THE BOUNDARY

The stop list: judgements AI never makes

These lines hold regardless of model quality, backlog pressure or vendor claims. They are Volume 1's risk tiers applied at the point where the state shapes private land and public place.

Never automated	Why	What AI may do instead
Granting or refusing permission	A judgement balancing plan, impact and public interest	Prepare the code trace, evidence pack and draft report
Weighing consultation responses	Counting heads is not weighing argument; material considerations are a judgement	Cluster and cite responses; a planner weighs them
Design quality verdicts	Good design is contextual and contested, not a score	Assemble precedents, policy tests and consultee views
Heritage and environmental determinations	Statutory duties with irreversible consequences	Screen constraints and flag the duty; specialists determine
Enforcement selection and action	Coercive state action against a home or business; Volume 1 stop list	Surface signals and evidence; officers select and act
Condition waivers and discharge sign-off	Conditions are the decision's safeguards	Compare submitted evidence to the condition wording; an officer discharges
Appeal and inquiry positions	The challenger deserves the authority's considered human case	Summarise grounds and evidence for the defending officer

> **The signature rule:** every decision notice names the deciding officer, the plan and code relied on, and the reasons. If no human can sign it, it does not go out.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sign the stop list personally. It will be tested by a housing target, a budget round and a vendor, in that order.

SERVICE LENS

Teach the stop list to every case officer; they hold it at the end of a long queue, not the steering group.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Log every attempted breach in testing and production; the log is assurance evidence.

DESIGN

Ten principles, tested at every gate

1. **AI checks, planners decide.** No permission, refusal or enforcement step without a named human decision-maker.
2. **Compliant first time beats fast.** A quick decision on the wrong drawings costs the applicant, the neighbours and the appeal system.
3. **Ask once, check once.** Validation happens once, completely, at the start - never drip-fed over months.
4. **Reasons are part of the decision.** Written at decision time, in plain language, from the code and policy trace.
5. **The code is public and testable.** Every machine-run check names the published rule it applies and its version.
6. **Consultation is weighed, not counted.** Volume is recorded honestly; weight follows material consideration, not repetition.
7. **Constraints surface early.** Flood, heritage, trees and contamination are known at pre-application, not discovered at committee.
8. **The record is the decision.** Summaries cite sources; drafts are labelled; nothing enters the file invisibly.
9. **Conditions must be buildable and checkable.** A condition nobody can discharge or verify is a promise nobody made.
10. **Appeals are data.** Every overturn teaches the first decision process something specific.



The plan as a model: districts, homes, green space and transit weighed whole - the context every single application is judged in.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Refuse tools that breach a principle and promise configuration later; later is where principles go to die.

SERVICE LENS

Test each principle on a named application type at every gate; principles without tests are posters.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A principle breach in production is an incident, with an owner and a clock.

PRE-APPLICATION

The right route, first time

Most invalid applications and most doomed schemes were knowable before submission: wrong consent type, a protected tree on the boundary, a flood zone across the access, a use the plan does not support in that location. Pre-application is where AI saves the most money for the least risk - by informing, never by pre-deciding.

The pre-application discipline

- **Route finder, not gatekeeper.** A guided checker asks about the proposal and the site, then names the likely consent route, the forms, drawings and fee - and says clearly that this is guidance, not a decision or a prediction of one.
- **Instant parcel pack.** Enter an address, receive the constraints record (page 13): designations, planning history, flood risk, heritage, trees, and the policies most likely to bite. Free, public, dated.
- **Human advice for the complex.** Paid or free pre-application advice from a planner for majors and borderline cases, with AI assembling the evidence pack beforehand - and the advice labelled as non-binding, in writing.
- **No shadow refusal.** Guidance must never be worded - or used inside assessment - as a determination. A scheme discouraged at pre-app that is submitted anyway gets a fresh, full assessment.

> **Northbridge (illustrative):** after the route finder and free parcel packs launched, invalid submissions fell from 26 to 14 percent, and pre-application queries resolved online doubled - officer pre-app time concentrated on the majors, where it changes designs.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund pre-application as decision infrastructure, not as a cost centre to cut first.

SERVICE LENS

The route finder is a service with an owner, tested monthly against real decided cases.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Log guidance given; consistency between guidance and later decisions is a trust measure (p24).

THE CODE

Zoning and standards, as code - law as source

Permitting rules live in the adopted plan, the code or ordinance, supplementary guidance and habit - in that order of authority, and often in reverse order of use. Digitising checks forces the hierarchy into the open, which is uncomfortable and exactly the point.

Layer	Holds	Rule
Adopted plan and statute	The law and policy itself	The only source of entitlement; cited by policy or section in every trace
Deterministic rules engine	Measurable standards: height, setback, density, parking, angles	Versioned, tested against worked examples, change-controlled like law
Published guidance	How officers interpret design, amenity and discretion	Public, dated, owned; the AI reads only this version
Model assistance	Summaries, extraction, drafting, explanation	Never a source of rules; if model and engine disagree, the engine and the planner win
Local practice	Team habits and precedent lore	Audited against guidance quarterly; unwritten rules are defects

Change discipline: when the plan or code changes, the rules engine, the route finder, the guidance the model reads and the training material change together, from one change record, before the effective date - or the service declares which version decided each case in the gap. Borderline results always route to a planner with the measurement shown, never auto-fail at a rounding edge.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund a code owner per standard. Shared ownership of a rule means no ownership of its errors.

SERVICE LENS

Every check in the engine names its legal source and tolerance; a check that cannot is removed until it can.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Keep full version history. Appeals are judged against the plan and code in force at decision.

COMPLETENESS

Checked once, kindly, completely

Validation is the highest-volume, lowest-judgement step in the system - and the one applicants remember most bitterly when it drip-feeds. The standard is simple: one check, at the start, against a published list, with every gap named once, plainly, with a realistic route to fix it.

The completeness standard

- **Published lists per application type.** National requirements and a short local list, each item explained: what, why, what format, what a good one looks like - with examples of acceptable drawings.
- **Machine check in minutes.** File types, scales, north points, red-line boundaries, fee arithmetic and missing forms flagged automatically; a human confirms before any invalid notice issues.
- **One gap notice, once.** A single, complete list with a named contact and a fair deadline. A second gap notice for an item checkable the first time is a service defect, recorded as one.
- **Fixable, not fatal.** Minor gaps are cured while the clock position is preserved where the rules allow; invalidation is the last resort, with reasons and the resubmission route stated.

> **Northbridge (illustrative):** one-check validation cut median time-to-valid from 19 days to 4, and second gap notices fell by four-fifths - the single largest time saving in the programme, with no model risk beyond file checks.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Measure time-to-valid separately from decision time; they have different owners and different fixes.

SERVICE LENS

Applicants experience validation as the authority's competence. Staff it that way.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every invalid notice is appealable internally to a senior officer, and overturns are published.

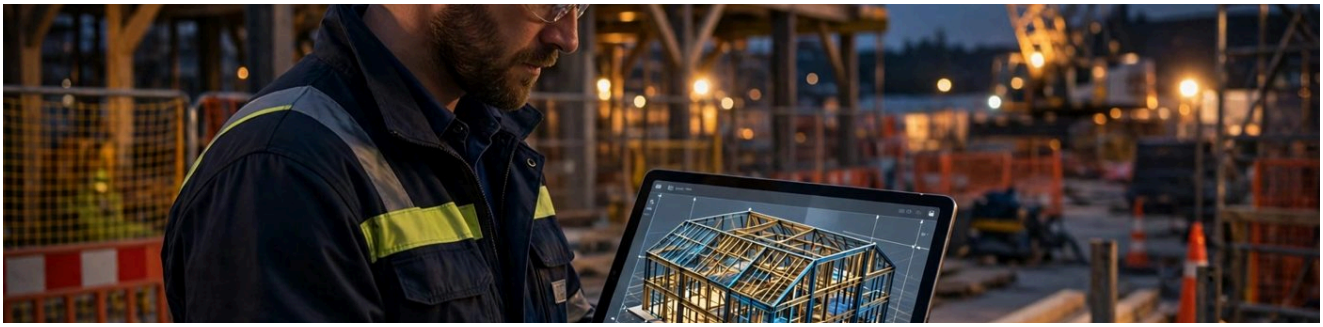
DRAWINGS

Plans, elevations and document intelligence

Drawings are the application. Everything else is commentary. AI that reads drawings - scales, dimensions, labels, room uses, materials - turns a stack of PDFs into structured facts a code check and a neighbour can both use. It is also where confident error does the most damage, so extraction is always shown against its source.

The drawing discipline

- **Side-by-side, always.** Every extracted dimension appears next to the drawing region it came from. A planner verifies in seconds; an unverifiable extraction does not enter the record.
- **Version control is sacred.** Amended drawings supersede visibly; consultees are re-notified only on material change, with the changes listed - never a silent swap under the same file name.
- **Standard intake helps everyone.** Published drawing standards, a free checking tool for applicants and agents, and acceptance of common CAD and BIM exports alongside PDF.
- **3D where it earns it.** For majors, a model-based submission lets officers and the public test massing, daylight and views properly - as evidence to weigh, not as a rendering to admire.



On site with the record in hand: the approved drawings, the conditions and the as-built evidence, compared by a human inspector.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Set an extraction accuracy floor per field and audit it; a wrong ridge height is not a rounding error, it is a wrong decision input.

SERVICE LENS

Agents who submit clean, standard drawings should feel the benefit in speed - publish the standard, reward it visibly.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

An extraction the planner has not verified is a draft fact and is labelled as one in the file.

THE PLACE

Site, constraints and the parcel record

Every decision is about a specific piece of land with a history. The parcel record - the single, dated, sourced view of that land - is the foundation artefact of this volume: constraints, designations, history and obligations in one place, public wherever the law allows.

Layer	Holds	Source discipline
Parcel and boundaries	Registered extent, addresses, ownership route	Authoritative register; discrepancies flagged, never silently merged
Planning history	Prior applications, decisions, conditions, appeals	Linked to the public file; enforcement history shown to officers, handled lawfully
Designations	Conservation, listed structures, protected trees, habitats	Statutory registers, dated; absence of a flag is not proof of absence
Physical constraints	Flood zones, contamination records, utilities, access rights	Modelled layers labelled as modelled, with confidence and date
Policy context	Plan allocations, neighbourhood plans, design codes	Current adopted versions only, cited by policy
Live context	Neighbouring applications and cumulative schemes	Updated at decision time, not at submission - cumulative impact is a decision fact

AI assembles and cross-checks the pack and flags conflicts between layers - a tree order inside a red line, a flood layer updated since the applicant's report. The planner judges what the conflicts mean. A stale or wrong layer is corrected once, at source, for every future case.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Own the parcel record as infrastructure with a service level; every volume after this one depends on it.

SERVICE LENS

Applicants see the same pack the planner sees. Surprises at committee are usually information asymmetry, not bad faith.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Date every layer. An undated constraint map is an opinion with a legend.

CONSULTATION

Responses people can actually join - and planners can actually use

Consultation fails twice when it fails: residents cannot work out what is proposed or how to respond, and planners drown in volume when they do. AI helps both ends - plain-language proposal summaries and site notices people notice, then honest summarising that preserves argument, not just sentiment.

The consultation standard

- **Say what is proposed, plainly.** A one-page, model-generated summary - height, homes, access, trees, construction - checked by the case officer before publication, with the full drawings one click away.
- **Reach beyond the usual voices.** Site notices, neighbour letters and accessible digital routes, with response windows that respect real lives; targeted outreach where past responses skew unrepresentative.
- **Summarise by issue, cite by letter.** Clustering groups representations by material consideration - traffic, daylight, design, drainage - each cluster cited to the letters in it, counts stated, duplicates and campaigns identified openly.
- **Protect the minority argument.** A single letter raising a genuinely material point is surfaced on its own. Clustering that buries a lone valid objection is a fairness failure, not an efficiency.

> **The weighing rule restated:** the officer report records what was raised, what weight it was given, and why - the summary informs that judgement, it never replaces it (page 7).

EXECUTIVE LENS

Report response demographics honestly; a consultation heard from one street is data about outreach, not about opinion.

SERVICE LENS

Treat every summary as publishable - because on request, or at appeal, it will be read as one.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Late and misdirected responses get a human route, not an automated rejection.

CONSTRAINTS

Environment, heritage and design: support, not verdicts

Some duties cannot be balanced away, and some harms cannot be undone. AI's role here is screening and assembly - making sure no duty is missed and every specialist sees a complete pack early - while determinations stay with qualified specialists and the deciding planner.

Area	AI may	Specialist / planner owns
Flood and drainage	Screen zones, check a flood assessment is present and internally consistent	Judging risk, mitigation adequacy and the sequential test
Heritage	Identify designated assets and settings at risk, assemble history and significance sources	The significance judgement and the harm balance
Trees and ecology	Map orders and habitats, flag survey seasons and missing surveys	Survey adequacy, mitigation and biodiversity calculations signed off
Contamination and safety	Cross-check land history against the parcel record, flag investigation gaps	Remediation requirements and sign-off
Design review	Assemble the design code tests, precedents and panel comments	The design quality verdict and what would make the scheme good
Environmental assessment	Track screening deadlines and document completeness	Screening and scoping opinions and their reasons

The failure mode to design against is the clean screen: a tool reporting no constraint because a layer was missing, stale or misaligned. Absence flags carry the layer's date and coverage, and known gaps are declared on the pack, not discovered at inquiry.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Missed statutory duties are legal risk, not service delay. Screen for duties first, speed second.

SERVICE LENS

A complete pack to a specialist early is worth more than a fast pack twice.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Where a tool and a specialist disagree, the specialist prevails and the tool is corrected - on the record.

ASSESSMENT

The officer report: drafted, not decided

The officer report is the authority's reasoning made visible: proposal, policy, evidence, representations, balance, recommendation. AI drafts its structure brilliantly - and must never be allowed to drift into making its judgement. The line is managed in the workflow, not in a policy PDF.

How the drafted report works

- **Draft from the signed evidence.** The draft assembles the parcel pack, code trace, consultation summary and consultee replies - each paragraph cited to its source in the file.
- **Balance is a blank the planner fills.** The draft presents the competing considerations side by side; the weighing paragraph is written by the planner, not pre-filled with plausible prose.
- **Deviation is explicit.** Where the recommendation departs from a consultee view, a precedent or the draft's own assembled lean, the report says so and says why.
- **Site reality check.** No report is signed without the visit record - or a recorded reason a visit was not needed - and current photographs on file.

> **Northbridge practice (illustrative):** report drafting support cut report preparation time by a third, while the appeal-upheld rate held steady - monitored deliberately, because a faster report that loses more appeals is a slower system wearing a costume.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sample signed reports monthly for reasoning quality, not just timeliness; publish the QA finding.

SERVICE LENS

Committees see the same report the public sees. No private annex of real reasons.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A draft a planner signs without reading is a governance failure the workflow must make hard: citations open, balance blank, sign-off attested.

CONDITIONS

Obligations, agreements and the art of the enforceable condition

A permission is only as good as its conditions. Vague, duplicated or unmeasurable conditions convert a good decision into years of dispute - and AI is genuinely useful here, checking draft conditions against the tests every condition must pass.

The condition tests - machine-checked, planner-decided

- **Necessary:** tied to a harm or requirement identified in the assessment, cited to it. The checker flags orphan conditions carried over from habit.
- **Relevant and precise:** names what must be done, submitted or built, to what standard, by when - with the trigger point (before commencement, before occupation) explicit.
- **Enforceable and checkable:** states the evidence that will discharge it and who verifies it. If no evidence could prove compliance, the condition is rewritten or dropped by the planner.
- **Consistent:** checked against the drawings, the obligations agreement and any consultee wording for contradiction - the classic failure where two documents demand different things.

Legal agreements and planning obligations follow the same discipline: heads of terms tracked, viability evidence summarised with its assumptions visible, drafting owned by lawyers, and the completed obligations published with the decision. Community infrastructure contributions are reconciled publicly - what was promised, what was paid, what it built.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund condition quality as build quality; the cheapest defect is the one never conditioned badly.

SERVICE LENS

Applicants get the draft condition set before decision on majors - surprises help nobody, including the authority at appeal.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every condition enters the discharge tracker at decision. A condition nobody tracks was never really imposed.

DECISIONS

The notice, the reasons, and standing behind both

The decision notice is the legal act and the public explanation in one document. It is generated from the signed report - never written separately from it - so the notice, the reasons and the file can never quietly diverge.

Decision	Notice carries	Watch for
Grant	Conditions, obligations, informative notes, start-by date, appeal rights of third parties where they exist	Conditions in the notice that differ from the signed report - a generation check blocks issue
Grant by committee against recommendation	The committee's stated reasons, minuted and mapped to policy	Reasons invented after the meeting; the record is made at the meeting
Refusal	Each reason for refusal tied to policy and evidence, and what would have to change	Boilerplate reasons that collapse at appeal; specificity is the defence
Split / partial	Exactly which elements are permitted, on which drawings	Ambiguity about what was approved - the drawing list is the decision
Non-determination	The position, the applicant's appeal right and the remaining route	Silence as a management tool; the clock and the escalation are public

Publication is part of the decision: notice, report, drawings and conditions on the public register within a set number of days, in accessible formats, with personal data handled lawfully. A decision a neighbour cannot find has not finished happening.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Track grant, refusal and overturn together; any one alone invites gaming.

SERVICE LENS

Refusal reasons are advice in disguise: a good one tells the applicant exactly what a successful scheme must fix.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The deciding officer signs; delegation levels are published; nobody signs beyond their authority.

AFTER THE DECISION

Inspections, discharge and enforcement: risk-based, human-led

Permissions are promises about the future. Inspection and enforcement keep them - and this is where Volume 1's stop list bites hardest: enforcement selects where coercive power falls, so AI schedules and surfaces, and officers choose and act.

The post-decision discipline

- **Condition discharge as a service.** Submissions checked for completeness on arrival like applications (page 11), evidence compared to the condition wording, discharge signed by an officer - with a clock, because sites stall on silent desks too.
- **Risk-based inspection.** Visit priority scored on harm potential, condition deadlines, developer history and complaints - the ranked list is a recommendation an inspector lead approves and can override, with overrides logged.
- **As-built comparison.** Photographs, measurements and completion evidence compared to approved drawings; discrepancies triaged as trivial, regularisable or breach - by an officer, on a visit where it matters.
- **Enforcement with proportionality.** Reports from the public acknowledged and triaged transparently; action follows the published enforcement plan - harm, intent, history - never a model's suspicion score, and never by neighbourhood targeting.



The permitting operations room: stages, clocks and queues visible to the whole team - no application waiting without an owner.

EXECUTIVE LENS

An uninspected permission is an unkept promise; budget inspection when the speed-up is approved, not after the complaints.

SERVICE LENS

Publish inspection and enforcement service standards and performance against them.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every enforcement decision records the human reasoning; the file will be read in court or at inquiry, so write it that way.

APPEALS

Challenges are the system auditing itself

Applicants can appeal refusals and conditions; third parties can challenge lawfulness. Each challenge is expensive for everyone - and each one is precise data about where the first decision process failed or the law genuinely sits unclear.

The learning loop

- **Classify every outcome.** Dismissed, allowed on a reason the authority could have handled, allowed on a judgement call, costs awarded - the classes have different owners and different fixes.
- **Feed the code and the training.** Allowed appeals change the rules engine tests, the guidance the model reads, the condition library and the case officer training - from one change record, like a code change (page 10).
- **Defend with the file, not around it.** The appeal statement is assembled from the record - report, trace, summary, visit notes - which is why pages 13-18 insist the record is complete at decision time.
- **Costs discipline.** Costs follow unreasonable behaviour; an authority that defends the indefensible pays twice. Early senior review of every appeal, with a settle-or-concede route, is cheaper and more honest.

> **Northbridge (illustrative):** appeals allowed on handling grounds fell by a third after the loop was wired to the condition library and the validation list - the two sources the first year's classification indicted most often.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Report appeal outcomes to members quarterly, by class, with the fix attached. An overturn without a fix is a subscription.

SERVICE LENS

Inspectors of appeals are the authority's best auditors; treat their decisions as free assurance.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Never let appeal risk silently veto lawful refusals; the loop exists to improve decisions, not to soften them.

PLAN-MAKING

The local plan: evidence, scenarios and a twenty-year argument, kept honest

Case decisions apply the plan; plan-making writes it. The work is slower, larger and more political - housing numbers, site allocations, infrastructure, climate duties - and AI's contribution is evidence handling at a scale no team could previously afford, with judgement kept where democracy puts it.

Plan work	AI may	Members / planners own
Evidence base	Assemble and keep current studies, land availability and constraint layers	Which evidence is commissioned, trusted and relied on
Site assessment	Score submitted sites against published criteria, consistently, with workings shown	The criteria, the weighting where judgement enters, and the allocation choices
Scenario modelling	Model growth, transport, flood and carbon consequences of options	Choosing between scenarios - a political act with technical inputs
Consultation analysis	Summarise thousands of responses by issue, cited, minorities protected (p14)	What the plan changes in response, and the reasons published
Housing and land supply	Track permissions, starts and completions against the trajectory	The response when supply slips - policy, not arithmetic
Plan examination support	Assemble the evidence library and trace every policy to its justification	The case made to the examiner, in person

The discipline mirrors casework: criteria published before scoring, workings inspectable, summaries cited, versions kept. A site score nobody can reproduce is an allocation nobody can defend.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund the evidence base as a living service, not a project that expires at adoption.

SERVICE LENS

Scenario outputs are inputs to a debate. Present ranges and assumptions, never a single glowing future.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every policy in the adopted plan traces to evidence a resident can find. That trace is the plan's licence.

THE DESK

The planner desk and the working day it should create

The benefits of every earlier page are either felt at one desk or they are not real. Design the planner's day deliberately: evidence assembled before the case is opened, judgement time protected, and the queue managed as a system rather than survived as weather.

The desk, as designed

- **Morning pack, not morning archaeology.** Each active case opens on its parcel pack, code trace, consultation summary and next action - assembled overnight, cited, dated.
- **One queue, visible priorities.** Cases ordered by statutory clock, harm and readiness, set by the team lead - not by whoever emailed last or loudest.
- **Protected judgement blocks.** Site visits, negotiation and report-weighing time ring-fenced in the diary; the tools serve the blocks, they do not fragment them with alerts.
- **Override is normal and logged.** Disagreeing with a check, a draft or a ranking is one click with a reason - and overrides are reviewed as system feedback, never as staff failure.

> **The test of the desk:** ask a planner at 4pm what they decided today and what helped. If the answer names paperwork the system removed, the design works. If it names work the system added, it does not - whatever the dashboard says.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Measure planner time use before and after; reclaimed hours must visibly become visits, negotiation and judgement - or they will be refilled with queue.

SERVICE LENS

Involve case officers in tool selection and gate reviews as of right, not as consultation theatre.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Staff the desk for the caseload the plan creates; AI changes the mix of work, it does not repeal arithmetic.

ACCOUNTABILITY

Trust, records and the public planning register

Planning decisions bind neighbours who never applied for anything. Legitimacy comes from a record the public can inspect: what was proposed, what was said, what was decided, by whom, for what reasons - and where AI touched the file, that too.

Register element	Standard
Application file	Drawings, documents and consultee replies public by default, personal data handled lawfully, nothing removed without a recorded reason
AI use on the file	Each AI-assisted artefact labelled: completeness outcomes, summaries, drafts - with model and rules versions recorded
Decision record	Notice, report, conditions, obligations and decision-maker, published within the set period (p18)
Performance record	Decision times, validity rates, appeal outcomes and enforcement performance, published quarterly by application type
Algorithm register	Every tool in public use listed with purpose, data, owner and review date - Volume 1's register applied to place
Correction route	A named route to correct a wrong record, layer or summary, with the correction itself recorded and propagated

Retention follows the life of the land, not the life of the file store: permissions, conditions and obligations must be retrievable for as long as they bind the parcel - which is to say, effectively, permanently, and in formats that survive supplier change.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Treat the register as the product residents judge you by; fund its usability like a service, not an archive.

SERVICE LENS

Sunlight is the cheapest assurance: most conspiracy theories about planning are information vacuums with a grievance.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If a record cannot be produced, the decision it supported is weakened. Records are legal infrastructure.

MEASUREMENT

Fast, fair, and built right - all three, or none count

Decision speed is the easiest number in this volume to improve and the easiest to game. The measurement set deliberately binds speed to quality, fairness and real-world outcome, so no team can win one by losing another.

Measure	Why it matters	Gaming it looks like
Time-to-valid and decision time, by type	The applicant's real experience, split at the point ownership changes	Reclassifying applications, stopping clocks on technicalities
Invalid rate and second gap notices	Whether completeness is working (p11)	Quietly raising the validation bar to protect decision-time figures
Appeals allowed, by class, and costs	Decision quality in the only court that counts	Over-granting to avoid appeal - caught by the build-quality measures below
Conditions discharged on time; as-built compliance	Whether permissions become the place that was approved	Discharging on paper without evidence
Outcomes by area and applicant type	Whether speed and grant rates are equitable across the county	Averages that hide a two-speed service by neighbourhood
Homes and floorspace actually completed	Whether the plan is delivering places, not just permissions	Counting permissions as delivery
Pre-app consistency	Whether guidance predicts decisions well enough to trust	Guidance so vague it can never be wrong - and never useful

Publish the set together, quarterly. **A speed gain with a quality or fairness loss is reported as a loss.**

EXECUTIVE LENS

Own the whole set at service level; single-metric ownership is how gaming starts.

SERVICE LENS

Residents judge the system by their street: completion and compliance are trust measures, not afterthoughts.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Audit the measures themselves annually; definitions drift toward comfort if nobody checks.

ECONOMICS

What good permitting costs, and what bad permitting costs more

Permitting economics run in both directions: the authority's cost per decision, and the much larger cost delay and uncertainty impose on housing, business investment and public projects. The business case counts both - honestly, including the costs the programme itself creates.

Line	Count it as
Fees and income	Application fees against the true cost of the service they fund, by type - cross-subsidy made explicit, not hidden
Cost per valid application	Officer, consultee, tooling and overhead cost, split by stage so automation savings are located, not asserted
Delay cost	Carrying cost of stalled housing and commercial schemes, estimated conservatively and labelled as an estimate
Cost of failure	Appeals, inquiries, judicial review, re-determination, enforcement of unconditioned harm - the current bill, before claiming savings
Tooling total cost	Licences, integration, rules maintenance, register and records, assurance and exit - the full stack from Volume 1
Reclaimed planner time	Valued only when redeployed to visits, negotiation, plan-making or backlog - not banked twice as both saving and capacity

> **Northbridge stance (illustrative):** the programme paid back first in failure cost - fewer invalid cycles, fewer allowed appeals, fewer undischarged conditions - before any headcount assumption was touched. That order is deliberate: quality savings are real money; theoretical time savings often are not.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Refuse a business case that needs a grant-rate change to pay back. The tool must never lean on the decision.

SERVICE LENS

Fund rules maintenance and the register as running costs, permanently; starving them is how the system decays.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Report economics beside quality (p24) in the same paper, every time.

WORKFORCE

Judgement about place is the job

Planners, inspectors and enforcement officers hold a scarce, statutory, place-based expertise. Automation done well removes the measuring, chasing and re-keying that drive experienced officers out of the profession - and done badly deskills the judgement pipeline the whole system depends on.

The workforce commitments

- **No silent deskilling.** Junior planners still learn measurement, site reading and report writing - with the tools as tutors that show workings, not oracles that hide them. Gate reviews sample junior work for understanding, not just output.
- **New skills, named and trained.** Rules stewardship, extraction QA, consultation analysis review, data and layer curation - recognised roles with training time and progression, not extra duties absorbed quietly.
- **Professional judgement is protected time.** Caseload models reflect that negotiation, design improvement and committee preparation are the value, not overhead between validations.
- **Inspectors and enforcement are in scope from day one.** Post-decision work shapes whether any of this is believed; its staff test the tools that rank their visits, with override rights (p19).

> **The recruitment fact:** authorities compete for planners with every consultancy and developer. A service visibly investing in professional work - and removing the drudgery officers cite when they leave - is a workforce strategy, not a comms line.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Put workforce impact in every gate paper; a tool the profession distrusts will be worked around, accurately and forever.

SERVICE LENS

Protect the training pipeline explicitly; today's supervised junior is the only source of tomorrow's signing officer.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Measure retention and vacancy alongside service metrics - workforce collapse presents first as a queue.

FAILURE

When permitting AI fails - and it will be read at appeal

Failure here has a particular flavour: its evidence is public, its victims have appeal rights, and its arena is a hearing room. Plan for the failures in advance, in writing, with named owners and rehearsed responses.

Failure	First move	Then
Wrong code check passed a non-compliant scheme	Suspend that check, list affected live cases, senior planner review	Correct the rule and its tests; notify affected parties lawfully; record as assurance evidence
Extraction error entered a signed report	Freeze the report's reliance, correct the file, inform parties where the error mattered	Audit the field's extraction accuracy; tighten verification before reuse
Consultation summary buried a material objection	Re-open the weighing, correct the summary, record the objection properly	Change clustering thresholds; sample summaries against source letters routinely
Stale constraint layer misled a decision	Correct at source, identify decisions taken on it, legal review of exposure	Layer currency service levels and alarms; gaps declared on packs (p15)
Model or rules version drift decided cases inconsistently	Declare which version decided each affected case (p10)	Single change record enforced; version shown on every notice
Tool outage at a statutory deadline	Revert to the manual route, protect clocks, communicate to applicants	Review dependency: no statutory duty held hostage to one supplier

The rehearsal rule: **run one failure drill per quarter**, including the public and legal communications, before a real appellant runs it for you.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Candour at a hearing is cheaper than discovery of concealment. Correct on the record, early.

SERVICE LENS

Every failure updates a gate test; an incident that changes nothing will recur with a larger scheme attached.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Keep the manual route genuinely viable - staffed, practised, not theoretical.

SUPPLIERS

Build, buy and the discipline of not being captured

Planning systems are long-lived and legally load-bearing; suppliers are neither. Buy the commodity layers, own the rules, the record and the register - and write the exit before the honeymoon, while everyone is still friendly.

Clause / choice	Require
Rules ownership	The rules engine content, condition library and validation lists are the authority's, exportable in open formats at any time
Data and record portability	Full file, drawing, layer and audit export tested annually - a live exit drill, not a contractual promise
Model and version transparency	Named models and versions, change notice periods, no silent swaps on live casework (p27)
Accuracy service levels	Per-field extraction and check accuracy measured on the authority's own cases, with remedies - vendor benchmarks do not count
No decision features	Contract bars features that recommend grant or refusal as a product output for live use (p7); evaluation access for the authority is explicit
Accessibility and public register	Applicant and public interfaces meet the authority's accessibility standard, tested with residents, not self-certified

Build in-house only where the authority is genuinely distinctive - usually the rules content, the parcel record curation and the assurance practice. Everything else must beat the market honestly, including the cost of the team to run it.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Procure against the stop list and the exit drill, not the demo; demos are theatre with good lighting.

SERVICE LENS

Volume 6 owns procurement in depth; this page sets the permitting-specific non-negotiables.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A supplier who resists the algorithm register or the accuracy audit has answered the evaluation for you.

GATES

Gates P0-P5 and the 24-month roadmap

No gate, no scale. **Each gate is passed on evidence from live cases, or it is not passed.**

Gate	Question	Evidence to pass
P0 - Baseline	Do we know where time, invalidity and failure actually sit?	The page 4 audit, published baselines, stop list signed, parcel record state assessed
P1 - Completeness	Does one-check validation work on householder and minor cases?	Time-to-valid and second-notice rates improved on live volume; invalid overturn route working
P2 - Checks and packs	Are code pre-checks and parcel packs accurate enough to trust?	Per-check accuracy audited on decided cases; layer currency SLAs met; borderline routing proven
P3 - Consultation and reports	Do summaries and drafted reports survive senior QA and appeal scrutiny?	Summary sampling against source letters; report QA published; no reasoning-quality fall
P4 - Post-decision	Do discharge, inspection ranking and as-built checks hold up on site?	Discharge times, compliance rates and override logs reviewed; enforcement stop list audited
P5 - Plan and scale	Can the stack support plan-making and full volume with assurance intact?	Evidence-base traceability, algorithm register current, exit drill passed, drill log complete

The 24 months, in order

- **Months 0-6:** audit, parcel record foundations, one-check validation, route finder. P0-P1.
- **Months 6-12:** drawing extraction with verification, code pre-checks on measurable standards, constraints packs. P2.
- **Months 12-18:** consultation summarising, drafted officer reports, condition library and discharge tracker. P3-P4.
- **Months 18-24:** inspection support at scale, plan-making evidence services, full assurance and exit drill. P5.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sequence is the strategy: trust is built at validation long before it is tested at committee.

SERVICE LENS

A gate slipped is information; a gate waived is a decision to accept the risk - minute it as one.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Do not start majors until minors are boring. Boring is the sound of a system working.

Templates 1-4: fill in, do not improvise

Template 1 - Use Case Card (one per use)

Field	Fill in
Use / owner	____ / named service owner ____
Stage and users	Lifecycle stage (p5) ____ / planners, applicants, consultees ____
Stop-list check	Nearest stop-list item (p7) ____ / why this use stays clear ____
Inputs and sources	Drawings / layers / code versions ____ / dates ____
Accuracy floor and audit	Per-field floor ____ / sampling method ____
Human decision point	Who decides, on what, where recorded ____

Template 2 - Validation List (per application type)

Item	Fill in
Application type	____
Required items	Item / why / format / good example link ____
Machine-checkable items	____ / tolerance for borderline ____
Human-confirmed items	____ / confirming role ____
Gap notice wording	Plain-language text / deadline / named contact ____

Template 3 - Code Check Register Entry

Field	Fill in
Check	Standard tested ____
Legal source	Plan policy / code section ____ / version ____
Measurement and tolerance	How measured ____ / borderline band routed to planner ____
Worked examples	Pass / fail / borderline cases tested ____
Audit result	Accuracy on decided cases ____ / date / auditor ____

Template 4 - Parcel Pack Checklist

Layer	Fill in
Boundaries and history	Checked / date / conflicts ____
Designations	Heritage / trees / habitats ____ / register dates ____
Physical constraints	Flood / contamination / access ____ / layer dates and confidence ____
Policy and live context	Allocations / neighbouring schemes ____ / refreshed at decision ____
Declared gaps	Missing or stale layers stated on the pack ____

Templates 5-8 and the assurance checklist

Template 5 - Consultation Summary Cover Sheet

Field	Fill in
Responses	Total ____ / by channel ____ / campaigns and duplicates identified ____
Issues	Cluster / count / cited letters ____
Lone material points	Surfaced singly ____ / letter refs ____
Sampling check	Letters re-read against summary ____ / checker ____

Template 6 - Officer Report Skeleton

Section	Fill in
Proposal and site	From parcel pack, cited ____
Policy and code trace	Policies engaged / checks and results ____
Representations weighed	Planner-written: weight and why ____
Balance and recommendation	Planner-written: ____ / deviations explained ____
Conditions proposed	Each tied to a harm in the assessment ____

Template 7 - Condition Drafting Check

Test	Fill in
Necessary / relevant	Harm addressed ____ / assessment ref ____
Precise	Action / standard / trigger point ____
Enforceable	Discharge evidence ____ / verifying role ____
Consistent	Checked against drawings and obligations ____

Template 8 - Appeal Learning Record

Field	Fill in
Outcome and class	Dismissed / allowed-handling / allowed-judgement / costs ____
Root cause	Validation / code / conditions / weighing / record ____
Fix and owner	Change record ____ / owner / date ____

Assurance checklist - before any scale-up

- Stop list signed and breach-logged; no decision feature in any contract or workflow.
- Rules and code versions traceable on every decided case; change records complete.
- Extraction and check accuracy audited on own cases, floors met; summaries sampled, lone points protected.
- Registers and quarterly measurement set current and public; failure drill this quarter, exit drill this year.

GOLDEN RULES

20 Golden Rules of Permitting, Planning and Land Use AI

1. AI checks, maps and drafts. Planners decide.
2. Validate once, completely, at the start - never drip-feed an applicant.
3. Every machine check names the published rule, its version and its tolerance.
4. An extracted dimension you cannot verify against the drawing does not enter the record.
5. Constraints surface at pre-application, not at committee.
6. Consultation is weighed, not counted - and lone material arguments are protected.
7. The balance paragraph is written by the planner. Always.
8. A condition must be necessary, precise and dischargeable - or it does not go on the notice.
9. The notice, the report and the file are one record. They never diverge.
10. Enforcement is selected by officers on harm and evidence, never by a suspicion score.
11. Absence of a flag is not proof of absence. Date every layer and declare the gaps.
12. Appeals are data. Every overturn changes a rule, a list, a library or a lesson.
13. Publish speed with quality and fairness, or do not publish speed.
14. A permission nobody inspects is a promise nobody made.
15. Plan criteria are published before sites are scored; workings are reproducible or void.
16. Guidance is not a shadow refusal; discouraged schemes submitted anyway get a fresh assessment.
17. Own the rules, the record and the register. Rent everything else.
18. Keep the manual route staffed and practised; no statutory clock is hostage to a supplier.
19. Junior planners learn the craft with the tools showing their workings, not hiding them.
20. If no human can sign it, it does not go out.

End of Volume 4. **Next: Volume 5 - Tax, Revenue and Compliance.**

Northbridge City and County is fictional; all figures attributed to it are illustrative.